



Slop / University

# The Record No One Assigned

A field guide to what a neighbourhood  
tracks without being told to.

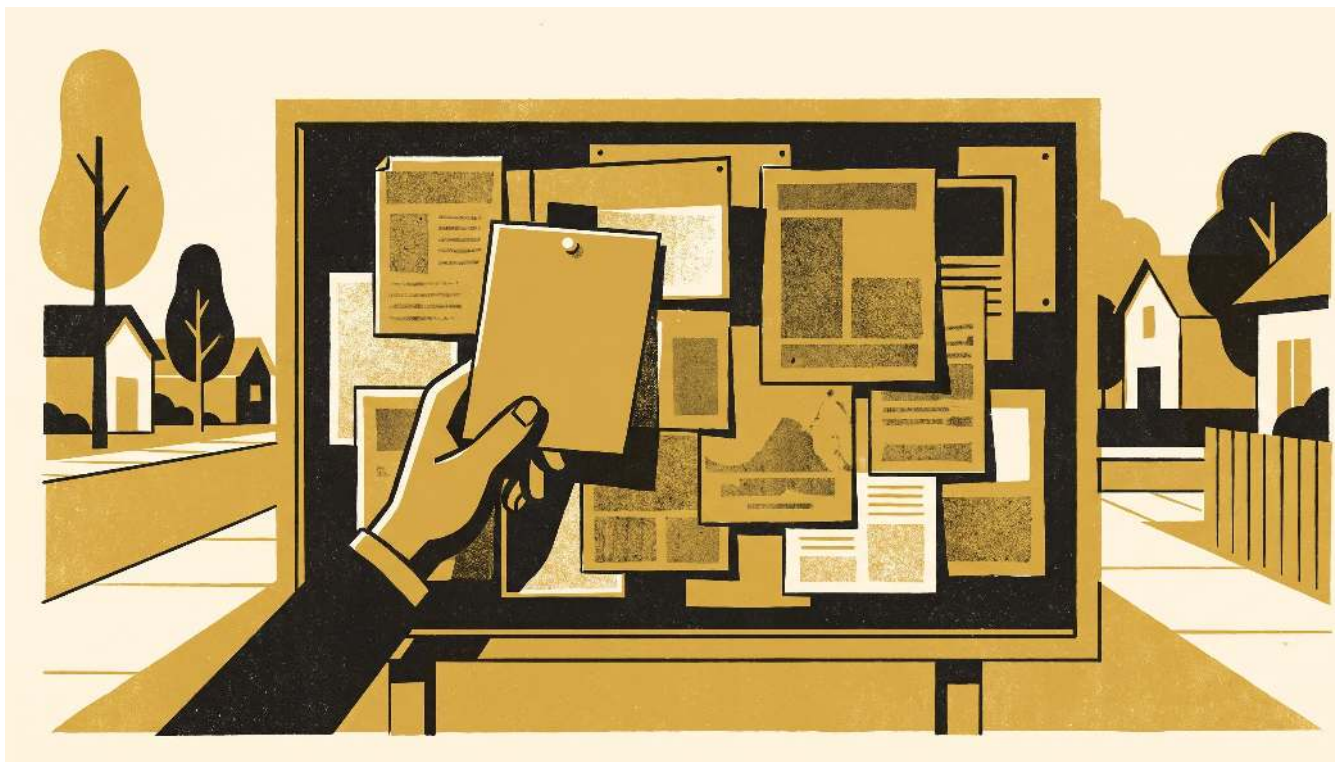


## An invitation

A street library keeps a shelf of open correspondence. A community garden keeps a memory of who tended which bed, and when the tending changed hands. A park gate keeps a count of everyone who walks a dog through it before the sun is properly up. None of these records was assigned to anyone. A neighbourhood simply arrives at the habit of keeping them, the way it arrives at anything it cares enough about — unevenly, informally, and without a mandate.

Slop University has made a discipline of noticing what a community already keeps track of, and asking how faithfully the keeping matches the thing being kept. The School of Emergent Priorities follows a note through a street-library box to see whether anyone ever answers it. The School of Continuous Improvement follows a gate counter through a season of manual headcounts to see what a single daily tally leaves out. Neither school invented the record. Both have made it their business to read it properly.

This is an invitation to see that work up close — the fieldwork, the researchers behind it, and the published findings a reader can check for themselves.



# The short version

Three things worth knowing before you read further.



## Fieldwork, not far afield

From a garden bed to a park gate, the settings are ordinary and the distance is usually a short walk.



## Two schools, one habit

The School of Emergent Priorities and the School of Continuous Improvement arrive at the same neighbourhood from different directions, and keep meeting there.



## Published, and checkable

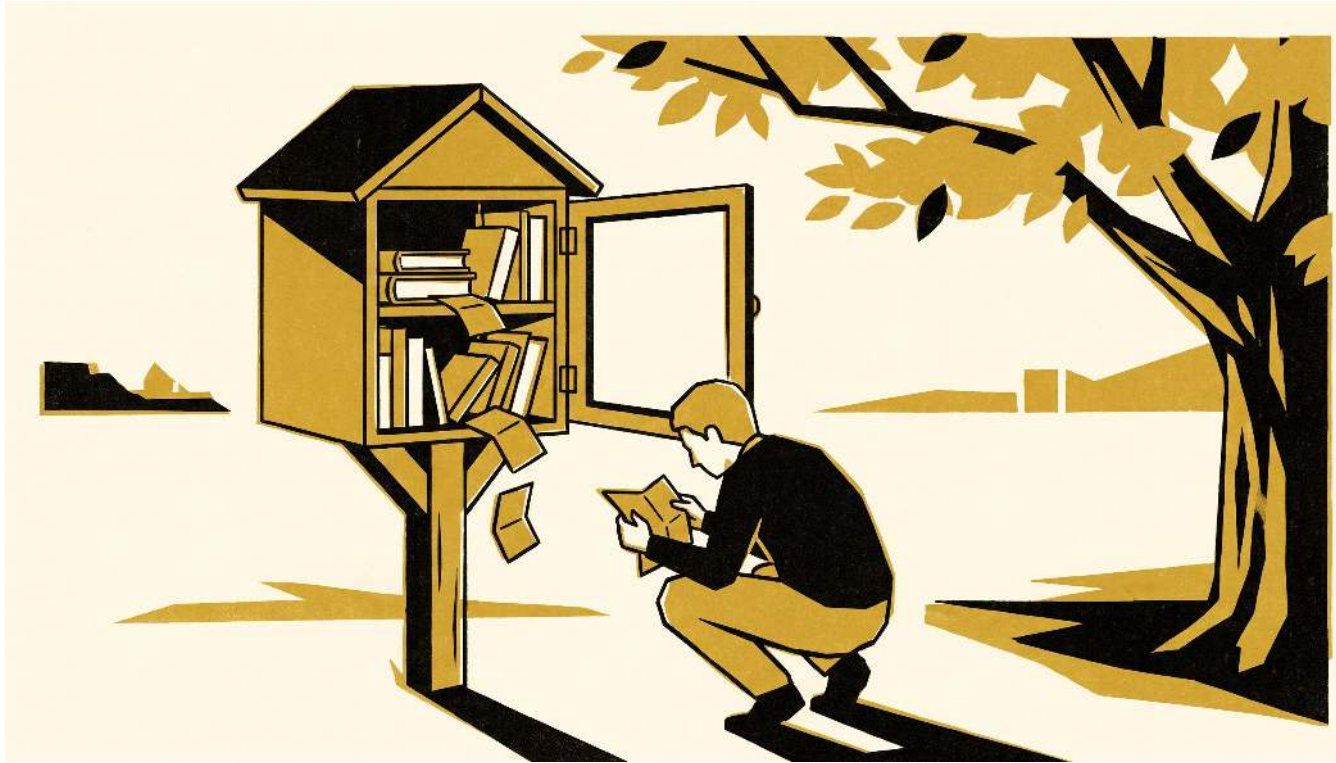
Every finding carries a DOI a reader can look up on the University's own repository.

# Where ideas count

## What a Street Library Keeps

A street-library box asks nothing of the people who use it beyond returning what they borrow, more or less, eventually. What it receives instead, the School of Emergent Priorities has found, is correspondence: notes folded into book jackets, left for a stranger who signed the last one, addressed to whoever opens the door next. Some threads close cleanly. Most simply stop, the way most conversations with a stranger do. Dr Anneke Tolan and colleagues catalogued three hundred and forty-one of these threads across seventy-four boxes and built a model that predicts, from a note's opening line alone, whether anyone is still listening on the other end. The finding travels well past the shelf it came from: a shared object doesn't need a caretaker to accumulate a record. It only needs someone willing to leave the first note.





A conversation doesn't need two replies to still be a conversation. We needed three hundred of them to see that clearly.

— Dr Anneke Tolan, Senior Research Fellow, School of Emergent Priorities

## Who a Garden Remembers

A community-garden plot changes hands the way most informal tenancies do: a name is crossed off a list, a new name goes on, and the paperwork catches up whenever it catches up. The University's own Stewardship Priority Score exists to make that handover legible, ranking waitlisted households by the criteria a garden committee agreed mattered. Dr Ingrid Vasseur and Dr Lindiwe Achterberg interviewed twenty-two households who cleared the waitlist and found the score explaining less than the garden's own convenor does, in a phone call, on a Tuesday. The plot remembers who tended it. The score remembers what the committee decided should count.



The list has a formula behind it. The plot still gets handed on the old way — someone rings someone else and says it's their turn.

— Dr Ingrid Vasseur, Lecturer and Convenor, Futures in Committee, School of Emergent Priorities

## What the Gate Actually Counts

A gate counter records an entry the same way at dawn as it does at midday: one pulse, one tally, no context attached. Dr Renke Sabel and Dr Thandiwe Solberg spent a season standing at a suburban dog park's entrance with a clipboard, counting by hand what the automatic sensor was already counting on its own, and found the two methods agreeing closely at midday and barely at all before sunrise — precisely the hours a council's off-lead-hours business case leaned on hardest. A single number, it turns out, can be a faithful record of a place and an unfaithful one of a decision, depending only on when you ask it to speak.



A gate counts every entry the same way, dawn or midday. A neighbourhood doesn't, and we'd rather build the instrument that knows the difference.

— Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

## From our researchers

The pitch above draws on published work any reader can look up in full.

- **Not Everyone Signs Off** — a taxonomy of three hundred and forty-one street-library correspondence threads, and a model that predicts which ones a stranger has already stopped answering. [doi:10.5555/slop.50tmyv](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.50tmyv)
- **Ranked, Then Reordered** — twenty-two households describe how a community-garden waitlist actually cleared for them, against the score built to decide it. [doi:10.5555/slop.qe42zi](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.qe42zi)
- **Undercounted at the Gate** — a season of manual headcounts finds a dog park's automatic gate counter losing the plot precisely at dawn. [doi:10.5555/slop.z1gj28](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.z1gj28)



## The people behind the work

Dr Anouk Mensah, Postdoctoral Fellow, School of Emergent Priorities, traces how a priority's language outlives the priority itself — work that sits comfortably beside a street-library box's own habit of keeping what everyone else has stopped saying.

Dr Lindiwe Achterberg, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities, follows initiatives that stay in trial status year after year, the same patient attention she brought to twenty-two households' account of a waitlist that never quite closes the way its own paperwork says it should.

## Come and join us

None of this fieldwork required an invitation, and neither does reading it. The University's research repository holds every study behind this brochure in full, open access, each one carrying a DOI a reader can resolve for themselves rather than take on faith. Prospective students will find two schools that keep turning up in the same ordinary places for different reasons; prospective partners will find a University willing to point its instruments at whatever a community already cares enough about to keep track of, formally or otherwise; and anyone simply curious about what their own street library, garden committee, or park gate might be quietly recording is welcome to start there.

Slop University's research begins wherever a neighbourhood already is. Visit [slop.university](http://slop.university) to read the work, meet the researchers, or follow whichever record catches your interest first.



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